Harry

By Rosemary Timperley

MOM: **(Pg 18-37)** Ordinary things make me afraid. Sunshine. Sharp shadows on grass. White roses. Children with red hair. And the name Harry. Such an ordinary name.

INTRODUCTION

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MOM: The first time Christine mentioned the name, I felt a premonition of fear. She was 5 years old, and she was playing alone in the garden, as she often did. I saw her lying on her stomach in the grass, making daisy-chains. The sun on her pale red hair made her skin look very white. Her big blue eyes were wide with concentration. Suddenly she looked towards the bush of white roses and smiled.

CHRISTINE: Yes, I'm Christine . . . With my mummy and daddy *(pause)* Oh, but they are my mummy and daddy.

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MOM: Uneasy, without quite knowing why, I called her, "Chris, come indoors now. It's too hot for you out there.

CHRISTINE: I must go in now. Goodbye.

MOM: Chris, who were you talking to?

CHRISTINE: Harry.

MOM: *(to Christine)* Who's Harry? *(to audience)* I couldn't get anything else out of her, so I read to her until bedtime. As she listened, she stared out at the garden. Once she smiled and waved. When Jim, my husband, came home I told him about the mysterious "Harry."

JIM: *(laughing)* It's not rare for only children to have an imaginary companion. She hasn't any brothers or sisters or friends her own age. So she imagines someone. I don't know what you're worrying about.

MOM: I felt consoled. Until next morning. Again, the sun shone on the small, bright lawn and white roses. Christine was sitting on the grass, cross-legged, staring towards the rose bush, smiling.

CHRISTINE: Hello. I hoped you'd come. How old are you? I'm only five. I'm not a baby! I'm going to school soon and I shall have a new green dress. Do you go to school? . . . What do you do then?

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MOM: She was silent for a while, nodding, listening, absorbed. I felt myself going cold as I stood there in the kitchen. "Don't be silly." I told myself. "Just carry on as if nothing were happening. Don't listen. Don't be a fool." But I called Chris in earlier than usual for her mid-morning milk. *(to Christine)* Your milk's ready, Chris. Come along.

CHRISTINE: Can Harry come too?

MOM: Who is Harry, darling?

CHRISTINE: Harry's my brother.

MOM: But Chris, you haven't got a brother. Daddy and mummy have only one child, one little girl, that's you.

CHRISTINE: Harry's my brother. He says so.

MOM: I came to dread those long summer days. I longed for the white roses to wither and die. I trembled when I heard Christine's voice prattling away in the garden. One Sunday, when Jim heard her at it, he said . . .

JIM: You know, I'm getting quite attached to young Harry. Wouldn't it be fun if one day we looked out and saw him?

MOM: Don't say that! It's my waking nightmare. Oh, Jim, I can't bear it much longer. Day in, day out, I hear

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nothing but 'Harry says,' 'Harry thinks,' 'Can Harry come too?' I'm afraid, Jim.

CHRISTINE: *(enters)* Harry's got red hair. Redder than my hair. And he's nearly as tall as daddy only thinner. He's 14. He says he's tall for his age.

MOM: She looked up as if at someone beside her. For a brief, dreadful second, I saw a shadow alongside her own - a long, thin shadow. Then it was gone. The child in my house was becoming a stranger. For the first time since Jim and I had adopted Chris. I wondered seriously: Who is she? Who were her real parents? Another week passed. It was Harry, Harry all the time. The day before she was to start school, Chris said:

CHRISTINE: Not going to school.

MOM: You're looking forward to it. There'll be lots of other little girls and boys.

CHRISTINE: Harry says he can't come too.

MOM: You won't want Harry at school. He'd feel silly among little boys and girls, a great lad of 14.

CHRISTINE: *(crying)* I won't go to school without Harry. I want to be with Harry.

MOM: *(angrily)* Chris, stop this nonsense! Stop it!

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CHRISTINE: *(eerily quiet and cold)* You don't love me. Harry loves me. He says I can go with him.

MOM: She slept with the tear stains still on her face. I went to the window to draw her curtains. Golden shadows in the garden. Then, like a dream, the long thin clear-cut shadow of a boy near the white roses -- a glimmer of red like close red curls on a boy's head. Then there was nothing. *(pause)* I told Jim about Christine's emotional outburst. *(to Jim)* Harry doesn't want her to go to school. . .

JIM: *(teasingly)* Believing in evil spirits at your old age?

MOM: I don't think Harry's evil. He's just a boy. A boy who doesn't exist, except for Christine. And who is Christine?

JIM: *(sharply)* None of that! When we adopted Chris, she was to be our own child. No probing into the past. Who is Christine indeed! She's our daughter!

MOM: He'd been so fierce about it that I didn't tell him what I planned to do the next day while Chris was at school. I kissed her goodbye at the gate, and I felt quite light-hearted as I walked away, knowing that Chris was safe and I didn't have to worry. I took a bus to the Greythorne Adoption Society. *(to secretary)* May I see

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Miss Cleaver? My name is Mrs. James. *(to audience)* Miss Cleaver, a tall, thin, grey-haired woman came to meet me.

MISS CLEAVER: Mrs James. How nice to see you again. How's Christine?

MOM: She's very well, Miss Cleaver. I'll get straight to the point. I know you don't normally divulge the origin of a child to its adopters and vice versa, but I must know who Christine is.

MISS CLEAVER: Sorry, Mrs James, our rules . . .

MOM: Please let me tell you the whole story, then you'll see I'm not just suffering from curiosity. *(to audience)* I told her about Harry.

MISS CLEAVER: Mrs. James, I'm going to break my rule. Christine was born in a very poor part of London. There were four in the family, father, mother, son and Christine herself.

MOM: Son?

MISS CLEAVER: Yes. He was 14 when -- when it happened. Let me start at the beginning. The parents hadn't really wanted Christine. The family lived in one room at the top of an old house which should have been

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condemned. It was difficult when there were only three of them, but with a baby, life became a nightmare. The mother was neurotic, unhappy. After she'd had the baby, she took no interest in it. The brother, however, adored the little girl. He got into trouble for cutting school so he could look after her. The father had a steady job in a warehouse, not much money, but enough to keep them alive. Then he was sick and lost his job. He was laid up in that messy room, ill, worrying, nagged by his wife, irked by the baby's crying and his son's eternal fussing over the child. Suddenly it all proved too much for him.

One morning, a woman in the ground floor room saw something fall past her window and heard a thud. She went out to look. The son was there on the ground. Christine in his arms. The boy's neck was broken. Christine was blue but still breathing faintly.

The woman woke the household, sent for the police and the doctor. They had to break down the door. An overpowering smell of gas greeted them, in spite of the open window.

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They found husband and wife dead in bed and a note from the husband saying: 'I can't go on. I am going to kill them all.' The police concluded that he'd sealed up the door and windows and turned on the gas when his family was asleep. But the son must have wakened. All he could do was pluck away the seals from the window, open it, and fling himself out, holding his adored little sister tightly in his arms.

MOM: Miss Cleaver, what was his name? *(to audience)* She referred to her files and said . . .

MISS CLEAVER: The family's name was Jones and the 14-year-old brother was called Harold.

MOM: Did he have red hair?

MISS CLEAVER: That I don't know, Mrs James. *(pause)* We don't think of children as having much memory, but there must be images of the past tucked away somewhere. Christine doesn't invent Harry. She ***remembers*** him. So clearly that she's almost brought him to life again.

MOM: May I have the address of the house where they lived? [And] I set out to find # 13 Canver Row. The house was filthy and derelict. But there was a tiny

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garden with one strange glory that none of the other houses possessed - a bush of white roses. They bloomed gloriously.

OLD WOMAN: What are you doing here?

MOM: It was an old woman, peering from the ground floor window. *(to woman)* I thought the house was empty.

OLD WOMAN: Should be. Been condemned. But they can't get me out. Nowhere else to go. That's where he fell. Among the roses. He still comes back--won't go away until he gets her. Harry Jones. Nice boy he was. Red hair. Loved Christine too much I thought. Go away, will you? This place isn't for you. It's for the dead who aren't dead, and the living who aren't alive.

MOM: *(to audience)* Mad people are terrifying. One can pity them, but one is still afraid. Then I heard something that chilled my blood. A clock struck three. At three o'clock I was supposed to be at the school gates, waiting for Christine. At last, I caught the right bus and reached the school. I ran across the empty playground. In a classroom, the teacher was gathering her books together. *(to teacher, gasping)* I've come for Christine.

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TEACHER: *(frowning)* Christine ***James***? Oh, yes, the little redhaired girl. Her brother called for her. It's sweet to see a boy of that age so fond of his baby sister. Has your husband got red hair, like the two children?

MOM: *(aghast)* What did - her brother say?

TEACHER: He didn't say anything. He just smiled. They'll be home by now, I should think.

MOM: I ran all the way home. *(entering the house frantically calling out)* Christine, where are you? Chris! *(to audience)* Even now I hear my own voice screaming through the house. "Harry! Don't take her away!" I rushed into the garden. The roses glared whitely. For a moment, I seemed very near to Christine, although I couldn't see her. Then the roses danced before my eyes and turned red. The world turned red. I fell through to nothingness - to almost death.

For weeks I was in bed. Jim and the police searched for Christine in vain for months. The papers were full of the strange disappearance of the red-haired child -- stories of kidnappings, child murders. Then the sensation died down. Just another unsolved mystery. *(pause)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Rosemary Timperley
Book: Roald Dahl's Book of Ghost Stories, Pgs 18-37
ISBN: 978-0374251314
Publisher: Farrar, Straus and Giroux
Date (Month/Year): Oct 1983

AWARD HISTORY

2024 National Qualifier – MS

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